

RESOURCE 11 · JOB SEARCH

Where To Network In Person

The online funnel is brutal because everyone uses the same one. Smaller rooms, with smaller companies, are where leverage hides.

THE MATH OF COMPETITION

Every senior IC is firing the same résumé at the same ten brand names. Big tech reqs get 1,000+ applicants; a Series B might get 40. Your odds change by an order of magnitude based on which room you walk into.

BIG TECH 1,000+

FAANG & the brand names

Meta, Google, Stripe, OpenAI, the usual suspects.

Per req: 1,000–5,000 applicants

Screened by: ATS, recruiter, panel

Referral helps: a little

Inbound rarely works. Don't make this your whole pipeline.

MID-SIZE 100–300

Series C through pre-IPO

Profitable scale-ups, recognized but not famous.

Per req: 100–300 applicants

Screened by: recruiter + hiring manager

Referral helps: a lot

A warm intro often jumps the queue entirely.

STARTUP 20–80

Seed through Series B

Names you have to explain at the dinner table.

Per req: 20–80 applicants

Screened by: founder or hiring manager

Referral helps: often decides it

A 20-minute conversation can put you at the top.

WORKING THE ROOM

→ Show up alone. You'll talk to twice as many people.

→ Ask "what are you working on?" not "are you hiring?"

→ Send the follow-up within 24 hours, by name, with one specific.

→ Skip the speaker. The lobby is where the work happens.

→ Leave with two names and a reason to follow up.

→ Go back. The third time you appear, you're a regular.

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Where to actually show up

Eight rooms where mid-size and startup teams are actively hiring, in order of how fast they pay off.

- 1 Tech meetups on Meetup, lu.ma, Eventbrite**
Filter by stack or domain. RSVPs over 30 usually means it's a real event with a real crowd. Stay for the second beer.
- 2 Demo nights and startup showcases**
Founders pitch on stage; engineers and EMs in the audience are often hiring. Talk to the second-row crowd, not the presenters.
- 3 Regional conferences, not just the big names**
SREcon, RailsConf, PyCon regional, AI Tinkerers chapters, local devops days. Smaller events; more real conversations.
- 4 Hackathons and build weekends**
You leave with a working demo and three people who saw you ship. Best signal-to-noise of any networking format.
- 5 Coworking spaces that host member events**
WeWork, Industrious, local indie spaces. Day passes work. Show up to the Thursday happy hour, you'll meet five founders.
- 6 University alumni nights and career mixers**
Even a decade-old alumni network opens doors fast. Most schools have a quiet local chapter you can crash.
- 7 Vendor and dev-tool launches**
AWS, GCP, Vercel, Linear meetups. Sponsors and speakers are almost always hiring; check their careers page before you go.
- 8 Invite-only dinners and IRL Slack/Discord meetups**
Ask one well-connected friend. These compound faster than anything else; the same 15 people show up to the next one.

THE FOLLOW-UP THAT WORKS

The room only matters if you write the email. Within 24 hours, by name, with one specific thing from the conversation. Ask for one small thing: a 20-minute call, an intro, a doc to read. The smaller the ask, the higher the yes rate.

"Hi Maria, great to meet you at the lu.ma meetup. You mentioned your team is rebuilding the ingest pipeline. I led a similar migration last year. Could I grab 20 minutes next week to compare notes?"